



# Windows Batch Files

Automate some mundane tasks in Windows using batch files

Rossi Fernandes

Batch scripts were an easy way to make tiny software necessary for drivers back in the days of DOS. DOS batch files can still be run in the same way in the Windows operating system through the command prompt. A few of the commands present in the DOS days don't exist anymore, but most are still intact. Batch files have the extension .BAT, and any text editor can be used to create them.

## Automate Your Net Connection

A lot of us use the dial-up method to connect to our ISPs—yes even the broadband users amongst us usually have to use PPPoE (dial-up broadband). The problem occurs often enough to be irritating—connections drop, for whatever reason, and downloads fail, transfers are restarted...you know what we mean. To automate the redialling process, make sure you have the account set up by going to Start > Control Panel > Network Connections. Open Notepad, and type in the following: RASDIAL <Connection Name> <username> <password>

You have to be careful to ensure that you type the connection name exactly as it shows in Network Connections. Now just hit [Ctrl] + [S], and save the file as <filename>.bat—here filename is whatever you want to call it. Now you can add a scheduled task to set the connection to dial automatically. Go to Start > Control Panel > Scheduled Tasks > Add Scheduled Task. Click Next and then click Browse and select the BAT file you just created.

Next, set the schedule for the application, so, say, you want to run the BAT file every day, after every half hour, just choose Daily and click Next. Fill in other details such as starting time, entering your user account information, and completing the schedule creation. To make this a repetitive schedule, right-click on the task, select Properties, click on the Scheduled tab and then on the Advanced button. Check the Repeat Task checkbox, and enter a value for the interval. You can be sure that your PC will, more or less, stay connected as long as it's on.

## Start Your Favourite Programs

As soon as you walk into office, you may launch Outlook to get your mail, open IE

to start browsing and perhaps launch your RSS reader. Designers may start work by launching another set of programs. Whatever your job, you're bound to have a few rituals like these, and instead of going through the motions every day, you can let a Batch file do all the work for you.

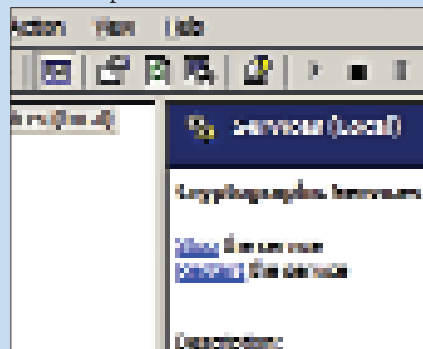
Start Notepad and create entries (as shown below) for all the applications you want to run one after the other.

```
CD "C:\Program Files\wings3d_0.99.00b"
Start Wings3D.exe
CD "C:\Program Files\Adobe\Adobe Photoshop CS3"
Start Photoshop.exe
```

CD is used to switch control to the directory of the application and the Start command runs the application itself. Once again, save the file with a .bat extension, and all you have to do is double-click this file when you want to start working.

## Start And Stop Services On Demand

Not all of us are blessed with fast computers, and even if you are, you might not like too many services running in the background. Normally, you could go to Start > Run and type net stop <Service> to stop services individually, but if you want, say, 10 services stopped when you're about to begin gaming, this would be painful.



Use the list of services to get exact names of services running on your Windows

With a Batch file, all you would need to do is create one that contains all the net stop commands in the following format:

```
NET STOP <Service 1>
NET STOP <Service 2>
...and so on
```

This way, you can add all the services you want stopped, and just double-clicking the Batch file will stop them all.

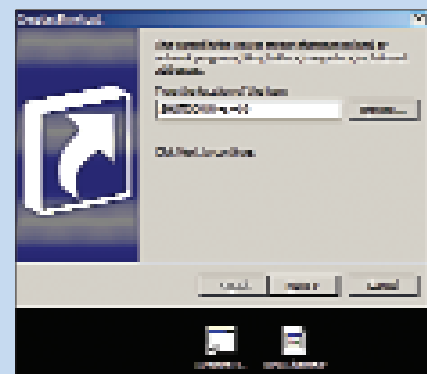
You can even do the reverse, and use the net start command to restart the same services using another Batch file. To find the exact names of the services, go to Start > Control Panel > Administrative Tools > Services; double-click a service and note down the name given under Service Name.

## Killing Tasks

Tasks can be shut in the same way services are stopped. The Taskkill command can forcibly shut applications from the command line. This can be used in a batch file to shutdown multiple applications together. This is especially useful in case you're usually goofing off and the boss walks in! In the batch file, create entries in this format: Taskkill /im Processname.exe /f.

## Quick Shutdown Or Reboot

There are commands that can be used to shutdown the computer and these can be customised as well. The command is shutdown -s -t 0. Create a shortcut



Creating shortcuts for the shutdown command is a quick way to shutdown and restart your PC

with this command and you can shutdown your PC without having to go to Start > Shut Down. This will force the PC to shutdown immediately without any confirmation dialog boxes. To set a time before the shutdown commands replace the value 0 with anything else. You can use this same command along with schedules to automatically shut down the computer. At any time if you want to abort the shutdown, use the command shutdown -a.

Similarly, the command for rebooting the computer without any alerts or confirmation windows is shutdown -r -t 0.

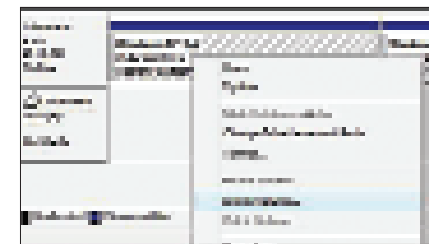
rossi.fernandes@thinkdigit.com

going to change that sad story. Download Power Defragmenter from <http://tinyurl.com/z74I3>. It is a user interface for a powerful disk utility named called Contig, which lets you defragment single files instead of blocks and sectors. Run the Power Defragmenter GUI and you will arrive at the screen shown.

The Defragment File(s) option lets you defragment up to four files, while Defragment Folder(s) lets you defragment up to four folders. You can also choose to defragment your entire hard drive. The process is very fast—the 82-minute defragment time for 25 GB in Vista Ultimate is cut down to just six minutes!

## Resize Partitions

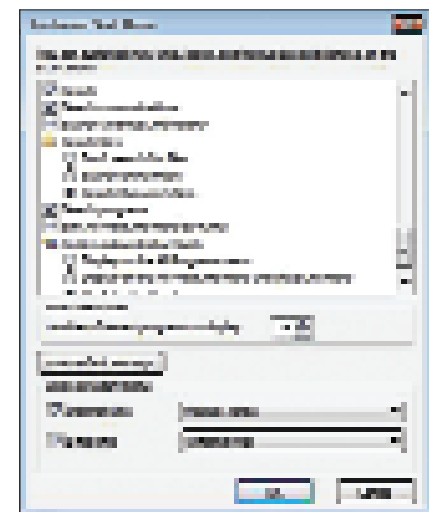
You can resize partitions in Vista without losing any data; start by backing up important data: it pays to be careful. Right-click on Computer and select Manage. Go to Disk Management under Storage and right-click on the partition you want to shrink. Click on Shrink Volume in the menu and voila: you have shrunk the disk.



Shrinking disk space in Vista

## Tweak Search Options

Windows Vista's search is completely revamped, and looks different when compared to XP. It also has more search options—different from the vanilla ones provided in XP. Right-

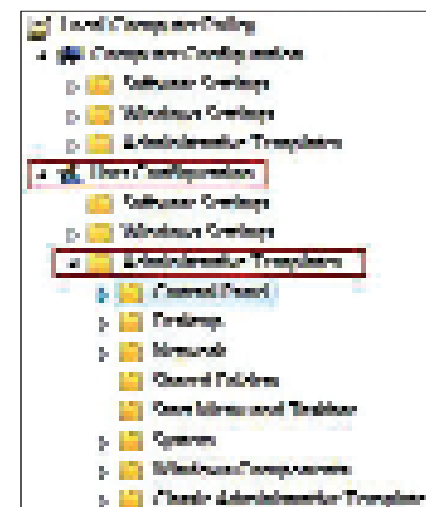


Various options in search

click on Start > Properties > Start Menu and click on the Customize button. A window pops up where you will be able to select the way searches can be made in your Vista Start box. The Search Communications option searches the files in Windows Mail and Contacts. Search Favourites and History searches the IE favourites and history. Search Files has further options: you can either choose to search the whole computer, or only files that you have created yourself. The final option is Search Programs. Depending on your preferences, searches will be done faster, or might even take more time than usual.

## Trim The Control Panel

The number of control panel items that we have to access regularly is miniscule. There is no sense in displaying all the icons as this slows down the loading time before you get to access the panel. The unused icons can be hidden by using the Group Policy Editor.



Tweaking the Control Panel

Go to Start and type gpedit.msc in the search bar. Go to User Configuration > Administrative Templates > Control Panel > Hide Specified Control Panel Items / Show Specified Control Panel Items. After enabling it, click on Show and type the name of the icon you want to hide or show. That has to be done exactly as written, with proper attention to case.

## Make ReadyBoost Default

ReadyBoost is a disk caching technology that kicks in when you attach USB flash drives. This optimises your system performance and is should be automatically switched on if you're

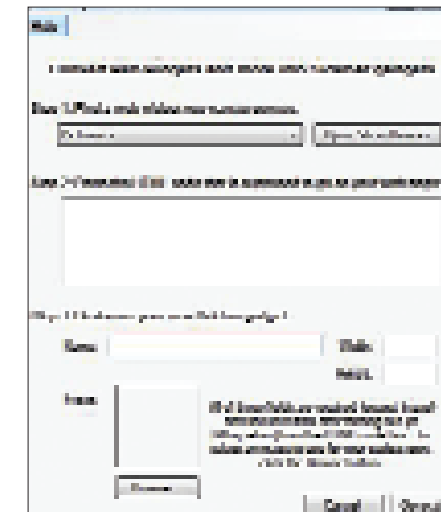
short on system memory and want to use a flash drive. However, no software is that intelligent, and in some cases this feature is not enabled automatically. A registry hack can, however change the way Vista deploys this feature. Proceed at your own risk.

Go to Start > My Computer > Right click on device > Properties > ReadyBoost. Select Stop retesting the device when I plug it in. Remove the device and open the registry editor—Start > type regedit in the search box. Navigate to HKEY\_LOCAL\_MACHINE\SOFTWARE\Microsoft\Windows-NT\CurrentVersion\EMDgmt and change these registry values: Device Status to 2, ReadSpeedKBs to 1000 and WriteSpeedKBs to 1000. Restart the machine, and ReadyBoost should be enabled every time.

## Get Widgets From The Net

Widgets and Google Gadgets can liven up a Web site. If you are a fan of any particular widget and you want to use it in Vista, you can now install these widgets in your Sidebar. For that, first download the Amnesty Generator from <http://www.amnestywidgets.com/GeneratorWin.html> (or get it off our October 2007 CD). After you have installed the program, get the source code of your favourite widgets and paste the HTML code in the space indicated by Step2.

You might also want to tweak with the HTML code a little to optimise the size parameters. Besides, you can also input the size in the boxes provided. Select an image for your widget and click on Generate. The Widget will be placed in your sidebar, and you will be able to check the daily weather, play games, get the latest stock quotes etc. In case you want to further fiddle with the gadget click on Start and type



Use Amnesty Generator to get your favourite widgets off the Internet